Password Management User Research Report

Group 5

Gabriel Galvis, Ernesto Hall, Kevin Hinojo, Alexander Jackson, Douglas Loia, Cassandra Thompson

1. Fieldwork Summary

This phase of the project focused on validating the assumptions made in the initial proposal regarding user frustrations, behaviors, and needs related to password management. Between February 16th and 21st, 2026, we conducted five semi-structured interviews using a standard Google Form. This method allowed participants to respond honestly and privately without pressure, which is especially important when discussing sensitive topics such as password habits.

Participants were recruited through personal networks, including classmates, coworkers, and peers in IT/computer-related fields. All participants are ages 18 to 52 and are in some form of computer or engineering field or study. All participants were informed that no real passwords, usernames, or sensitive credentials should be shared. Each participant voluntarily agreed to take part in the study, and all responses were semi-anonymized using only their first names. The goal of the fieldwork was to gather empirical evidence on how real users manage passwords, the challenges they face, and the features they value in a password management solution.

2. Methodology

2.1 Method Choice

The primary method used in this study was semi-structured interviews administered through a Google form. This method was chosen because password management behaviors are deeply personal. Interviews allow participants to describe their real workflows, frustrations, and coping strategies in their own words.

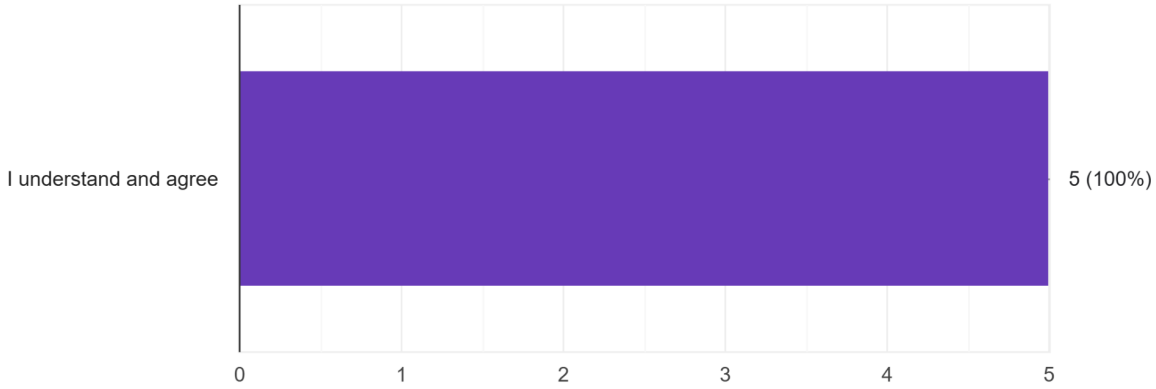
No observational sessions were conducted due to the private and sensitive nature of password usage. Observing participants entering passwords on personal devices would raise ethical concerns and risk exposing sensitive information. Instead, the study relied on participants to describe their most recent password related experiences.

We recruited five participants who represent a realistic cross section of the target demographic, individuals who regularly use multiple online accounts and interact with login systems on laptops, desktops, and mobile devices. Participants range from novice users who rely on memory to advanced users who rely on memory to advanced users who employ dedicated password managers.

All participants were semi-anonymized using only their first names. Only demographic information relevant to password management behavior was collected.

3. Participant Table

Acknowledgment By checking the box below, I confirm that I understand this survey is for academic research only. I agree not to provide any real usern..., or sensitive personal information in my responses.
5 responses



	Participant 1 (Jomel)	Participant 2 (Luke)	Participant 3 (Luke2)	Participant 4 (Paul)	Participant 5 (Eli)
Occupation / Field of Study	IT	Computer Science	Computer Engineering	Engineering	IT Consulting & Support
Estimated # of Accounts	10–20	20–40	10–20	More than 40	More than 40
How often new accounts?	A few times a year	A few times a year	Monthly	A few times a year	Monthly
Password Storage Methods	Browser password manager; Reuse passwords	Memorize; Browser manager; Reuse passwords	Memorize; Browser manager	“Other document”	Memorize; Dedicated password manager; Password-protected file
Password	Almost	Often	Sometimes	Often	Sometimes

Reuse Frequency	always				
Confidence in Security	Not very confident	Somewhat confident	Somewhat confident	Somewhat confident	Very confident
Most Frustrating Part	Updating every month & creating new passwords	Keeping track of multiple complex passwords	Computer resets & loses saved passwords	Trying to remember passwords	Password fails even when correct; reset conflicts
Ever Locked Out?	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
If Yes, What Happened?	Forgot password entirely	Couldn't figure out password	Computer repair wiped saved passwords	Had to reset passwords	Reset password or called admin
2FA Usage	Never	Sometimes	Sometimes	Sometimes	Always
Importance of Password Security	Somewhat important	Somewhat important	Important	Extremely important	Extremely important
Used a Password Manager Before?	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes
Liked About PM	Fast login	Stores & autofills	Don't need to remember passwords	N/A	Convenience; Security; Stores 2FA keys
Disliked About PM	Glitches; saves wrong password	Mixes up accounts	Forgets passwords	N/A	Conflicts with employer systems
Desired Features	Auto-generate; Secure	Auto-generate; Secure	Secure storage;	Easy retrieval;	Auto-generate; Secure

	storage; Autofill; Easy retrieval	storage; Autofill; Categories; Easy retrieval; Emergency access	Autofill; Categories; Easy retrieval; Emergency access	Emergency access	storage; Autofill; Categories; Easy retrieval; Emergency access; Affordability
Likelihood of Using New PM	Very likely	Somewhat likely	Very likely	Very likely	Somewhat likely
Additional Comments	Wants Chrome extension	None	None	Wants legacy/back up process	Fingerprint login ideal

These participants were selected because they represent a range of password management behaviors, from insecure habits (Password reuse, memory-based storage) to advanced practices (dedicated password managers, 2FA). This diversity helps validate whether the proposed solution addresses the needs of both novice and experienced users.

4. Data Synthesis

This section provides an organized synthesis of the raw participant data, presenting it in a clear and systematic manner prior to analysis or interpretation.

4.1 Interview Summaries

Participant 1 "Jomel"- IT

Jomel manages 10–20 accounts and creates new ones only a few times per year. They rely heavily on the browser's built-in password manager and frequently reuse the same password across accounts. They expressed low confidence in their security habits and frustration with constantly updating their passwords. Jomel has been locked out before due to forgetting a password entirely. They do not use 2FA and consider password security only "somewhat important." They previously used a password manager but disliked glitches and incorrect password saves. They would very likely adopt a new password manager if it included a Chrome extension.

Participant 2 "Luke"- Computer Science

Luke manages 20-40 accounts and often reuses passwords. They store passwords in memory, browser autofill, and repeated patterns. Their biggest frustration is keeping track of multiple complex passwords. They have been locked out before and sometimes use 2FA. They find password security somewhat important. Luke likes that password

managers store and autofill passwords but dislikes when they mix up accounts. They are somewhat likely to try a new password manager.

Participant 3 "Luke2"- Computer Engineering

Luke manages 10-20 accounts and creates new ones monthly. They memorize passwords or rely on the browser manager. Their main frustration is losing all saved passwords when their computer is reset or repaired. They have been locked out before and use 2FA occasionally. They find password security important. Luke likes that password managers remove the need to remember passwords, but dislikes it when they fail to save them. They are very likely to use a new password manager.

Participant 4 "Paul"- Engineering

Paul manages more than 40 accounts and often reuses passwords. They store passwords in a document. Their biggest frustration is simply remembering passwords. They have been locked out before and sometimes use 2FA. Password security is extremely important to them, but they have never used a password manager. They are very likely to adopt one, especially if it includes legacy/backup features.

Participant 5 "Eli"- IT Consulting & Support

Eli manages more than 40 accounts and creates new ones monthly. They use a dedicated password manager, a password-protected file, and memorization. They are very confident in their security habits and always use 2FA. Their biggest frustration is when password resets conflict with existing credentials. They appreciate convenience and security in password managers, especially those that store 2FA keys, but dislike conflicts when employers use the same service. They are somewhat likely to adopt a new password manager and prefer biometric login options.

4.2 High-Impact Quotes

These quotes capture the essence of the user's frustration and needs:

1) "Having to update every other month and coming up with a new password" - P1(Jomal)
2) "Keeping track of multiple complex passwords" - P2(Luke)
3) "When my computer resets and forgets all my passwords" - P3(Luke2)
4) "When you try your password, and it fails, but when you try to set a new password, it says it's already in use." - P5(Eli)
5) "Convenience and Security. I prefer the ones that store the 2FA key" - P5(Eli)
6) "Trying to remember the passwords" - P4(Paul)
7) "Sometimes it glitches and saves the wrong password" - P1(Jomal)

These statements highlight recurring themes: password reuse, memory overload, device-dependent storage, and frustration with unreliable tools.

5. Appendices

Below is the complete, unaltered dataset, including both the original Google Form response links and the full participant responses exactly as submitted.

Responder link
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSdieLp-zodwQ45x1o9gPb5FgZnnHjfzejY5VNuoTXeY93vLwg/viewform?usp=header

Responder responses
https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/15ZEkKJE9_1tQnG7Uqf8n16esqyKnRB0-0fDsStKcu4o/edit?gid=1113642702#gid=1113642702

6. Conclusion

The data collected from these five participants support the proposal's core assumptions. Many users struggle to remember passwords, manage multiple accounts, and maintain secure habits. Even participants with technical backgrounds reported frustration, account lockouts, and reliance on insecure workarounds. Since even technical users are experiencing problems with password management, it's fair to say this problem is widespread and might be even bigger than we think. Overall, the findings highlight a clear need for a password-management solution that is secure, easy to use, and reliable across devices.

Roles For the Project

Gabriel Galvis- Coding(Front/Backend)
Ernesto Hall- Writing and Editing
Kevin Hinojo- Coding(Front/Backend)
Alexander Jackson- Coding(Front/Backend) and finding Participants
Douglas Loia- Coding(Front/Backend)
Cassandra Thompson- Writing and Management/Organizing